



EAMR beings sampling

WD has started sampling 18 and 20 TB hard drives featuring its upcoming EAMR technology <https://dgit.in/jan20-41>



Picking an SSD or HDD

Here's a handy guide to help you figure out your storage needs so that you can buy the right drive <https://dgit.in/jan20-42>

THEY'RE "DRIVING" ME NUTS

External hard drives that don't deserve to command a price premium

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xternal hard drives are boring devices to talk about. I'd never imagined that I'd have to talk about external

hard drives in this day and age, especially since they've become commodities and barely have any worthwhile value additions that could sweeten the deal. In the past couple of years, manufacturers have been providing a few gigabytes of cloud storage space with each external hard drive but that's about it. Every now and then you'd see some manufacturers integrate additional media creation software with the drives and I can certainly get behind that but I could hardly be bothered with the rest. So why am I harping about external hard drives? Well, a buddy of mine came to me asking for buying advice. He wanted to buy an external hard drive for his Macbook Air and was looking for recommendations. A few cursory Google searches had him nearly convinced about getting either a LaCie or a G-Technology hard drive which tend to be a little more expensive compared to the usual external drives that we get to see from the likes of Seagate, WD, Toshiba,

Sony, etc. So he wanted to know why these particular hard drives commanded a premium and I'm certain some of you might be wondering the same.

There was a time when these hard drives actually were different from the other suspects. The primary differentiator was the interface and the file system with which they came pre-formatted. Apple devices such as Macbooks, Macs and Mac Minis used to have file systems which were different from what Windows PCs used. Linux systems were compatible with practically everything but the divide between PC and Mac OS in terms of file systems and also because the interfaces were different (PC used USB whereas Apple devices used FireWire) there was the need to have external hard drives that were purpose built to be compatible with these different platforms. Apple devices did have USB but FireWire was much faster and a



G-Technology External HDD

lot of external storage devices moved to using FireWire. What emerged out of this was that manufacturers would have separate product lines just for Apple devices. The LaCie and G-Technology drives trace their origins to this era. As a result of this exclusivity, these hard drives also started commanding a price premium which they still do to this day.

Things have changed

a lot since then. FireWire made way for Thunderbolt on Apple devices and the market for Mac OS specific devices still existed. However, when the Apple exclusivity agreement for Thunderbolt ended and the Thunderbolt protocol became compatible with the USB interface around the time USB 3.0 came out. As a result, both Apple devices and PC devices were shipping with the same interfaces. These days, a Type-C interface with Thunderbolt support is found on nearly all PCs and it is the standard on Apple devices. This meant that the only reason that macOS (previously Mac OS) and PC would require different external storage medium came down to the file systems. That was easily solved



LaCie External Hard Drive